



# Converging on Each Other, Not the Jar

## Guess-Spread Collapse Across a Visible Jellybean-Census Sign-In Sheet

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### Background

Union Market jar-guessing stalls pair a jar with either a sealed ballot box or an open sign-in sheet pinned beside it. Does reading who guessed before you make the crowd's estimate any better, or just any more alike?

### Aims

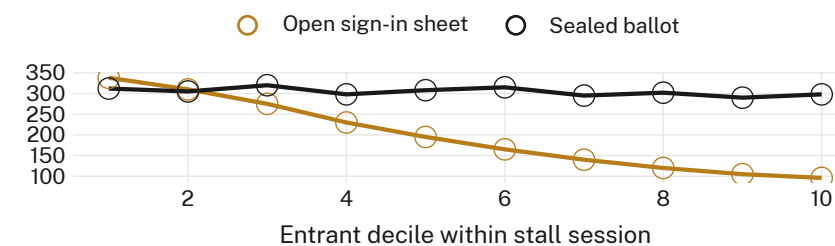
- Compare within-stall guess spread between sealed and open conditions across the entrant sequence.
- Test whether a narrowing open-sheet spread tracks improving accuracy against the jar's counted total.
- Check whether the Adaptive Metrics Lab's calibration reading survives a same-session accuracy check.

### Methods

- 11 Union Market stalls · 428 guesses (sealed n = 193, open n = 235) · 11-week term
- Condition set by rostered volunteer preference, not randomised; jar contents counted blind by organisers before each draw
- Spread = within-stall SD by entrant decile; accuracy = median | guess – counted total|

### Results

Open-sheet spread contracted sharply across the entrant sequence; median accuracy did not follow it down. See chart.



Open-sheet guess spread fell from a within-stall SD of 338 jellybeans among the first decile of entrants to 96 among the last, a 72% contraction across the Union Market's term-3 2026 run; sealed-ballot spread held between 290 and 320 throughout.

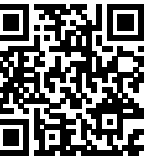
### Discussion & conclusions

The open sheet's narrowing spread never closed the gap to the jar's counted total: median absolute error rose 46% across the same decile split, while the sealed condition's error held flat. The Adaptive Metrics Lab's collective-estimation calibration reading treats agreement as accuracy; the counted jar disagrees. Next: the Library's estimate-the-queue board carries the same open sheet, unaudited.

### Selected references

1. Galton, F. (1907). Vox Populi. *Nature*, 75, 450–451. doi:10.1038/075450a0
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3. Jayles, B., Kim, H., Escobedo, R., Cezera, S., Blanchet, A., Kameda, T., Sire, C., & Theraulaz, G. (2017). How social information can improve estimation accuracy in human groups. *PNAS*, 114(47), 12620–12625. doi:10.1073/pnas.1703695114
4. King, A. J., Cheng, L., Starke, S. D., & Myatt, J. P. (2012). Is the true 'wisdom of the crowd' to copy successful individuals? *Biology Letters*, 8(2), 197–200. doi:10.1098/rsbl.2011.0795
5. Sabel, R., & Okwuosa, S. (2026). Counted Before It's Checked: A Clip-On Logger for the Shared AV Carts, and How Its Raw Ping Count Reached the Replacement Budget. Slop University Office of Research Outputs. doi:10.5555/slop.zhqdoo

Supported by an Adaptive Metrics Lab seed allocation. Jar contents counted independently before and after each draw; no entrant identifiers retained beyond stall and decile.



“The sheet agreed with itself in ten entrants. It never got closer to right.”

Median guess error rose 46% as the open sheet's spread fell 72%, Union Market, term 3, 2026.